

Error recovery states

Recoverable failure patterns for the Alpha prototype, with stable input and actionable next steps.

Handoff anchor	Beacon Field Research / Study Alpha / 2026-07-13 / session UX-184 / n=24
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Action	→ Detect	→ Explain	→ Recover	→ Reconcile
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Failure principles

Errors name what happened, preserve work, and offer the smallest useful recovery. Avoid blame, unexplained codes, and modal dead ends. The component that failed owns its recovery message.

Severity	Placement	Default action
Inline	Field or card	Correct or retry in context
Page-level	Below page title	Retry while retaining content
Blocking	Centered dialog only for required confirmation	Cancel returns unchanged state

State inventory

Each state has a deterministic trigger so observers can exercise it during a session.

State	Trigger	Message / recovery
Search timeout	No response at 8 seconds	"Search is taking longer than expected." Retry; keep query and filters.
Save conflict	Server disagrees with queued save	"Your saved list changed elsewhere." Review changes.
Network offline	Browser reports offline	"You are offline. Saves will sync when connected."
Permission unavailable	Share API declines	"Sharing is unavailable here." Copy study title instead.

Recovery acceptance

Errors use role=alert only when immediate interruption is necessary. Otherwise, status updates are polite. Retry receives focus only after the error message is announced. A failed retry does not stack duplicate alerts.